

# Japanese Writing Systems

Study cards for beginners



# Kanji 漢字

Chinese-origin characters that represent meaning. About 2,000-3,000 in common use.

## EXAMPLE

一

ichi

(one)

二

ni

(two)

三

san

(three)



あ

# Hiragana ひらがな

46 phonetic characters, one per sound. Curved, flowing strokes.

## EXAMPLE

あ

a

い

i

う

u

え

e

お

o



# Katakana カタカナ

46 phonetic characters, mainly for foreign loanwords. Angular, straight strokes.

## EXAMPLE

テレビ

**terebi**

*(television)*



# Roomaji ローマ字

Japanese sounds written with the English alphabet. 101 sounds total: 5 vowels, 95 consonant-vowel combinations, plus 'n'.

## EXAMPLE

**paatii**

*(party)*

**sofaa**

*(sofa)*

**chesu**

*(chess)*

# Roomaji Syllables Chart

Basic syllables (a / i / u / e / o) and contracted yōon sounds (ya / yu / yo)

## Seion (Plain Sounds)

|   | a  | i   | u   | e  | o  |
|---|----|-----|-----|----|----|
| k | ka | ki  | ku  | ke | ko |
| s | sa | shi | su  | se | so |
| t | ta | chi | tsu | te | to |
| n | na | ni  | nu  | ne | no |
| h | ha | hi  | fu  | he | ho |
| m | ma | mi  | mu  | me | mo |
| y | ya |     | yu  |    | yo |
| r | ra | ri  | ru  | re | ro |
| w | wa |     |     |    |    |

| a   | u   | o   |
|-----|-----|-----|
| kya | kyu | kyo |
| sha | shu | sho |
| cha | chu | cho |
| nya | nyu | nyo |
| hya | hyu | hyo |
| mya | myu | myo |
|     |     |     |
| rya | ryu | ryo |
|     |     |     |

## Dakuon & Handakuon (Voiced Sounds)

|   | a                         | i  | u  | e  | o  |
|---|---------------------------|----|----|----|----|
| g | ga                        | gi | gu | ge | go |
| z | za                        | ji | zu | ze | zo |
| d | da                        |    |    | de | do |
| b | ba                        | bi | bu | be | bo |
| p | pa                        | pi | pu | pe | po |
| n | <i>n (consonant only)</i> |    |    |    |    |

| a   | u   | o   |
|-----|-----|-----|
| gya | gyu | gyo |
| ja  | ju  | jo  |
|     |     |     |
| bya | byu | byo |
| pya | pyu | pyo |
|     |     |     |

# Long Vowels 長音

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Double vowels replace macrons for a long vowel sound (held twice as long). Vowel length changes meaning.

## EXAMPLE

**koohii**

*(coffee)*

**tori**

*(bird)*

**toori**

*(street)*

# Hyphens

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Mark word boundaries: after prefixes/before suffixes, between compound words, and before inflected endings.

## EXAMPLE

**o-cha**

*(tea)*

**Nihon-go**

*(Japanese language)*

**iki-mashoo**

*(let's go)*



# Apostrophes

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Mark a short pause after the 'n' sound, or show a contraction.

## EXAMPLE

gen'in

*(cause)*

fun'iki

*(atmosphere)*

# 'N' Sound

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Pronounced like 'm' before b/p/m, like 'ng' before g/k, and as a nasal sound before vowels, y/w, and s/sh/h.

## EXAMPLE

**shinbun**

*(newspaper)*

**kangae**

*(thought)*

**funsui**

*(fountain)*

**denwa**

*(telephone)*

# Double Consonants 促音

Sounds that merge together are shown by doubling the consonant.

## EXAMPLE

**hakkiri**

*(clearly)*

**massugu**

*(straight)*

**kitte**

*(stamp)*

**issho**

*(together)*

# Abbreviations

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Notation used in this textbook for questions, answers, and examples.

## EXAMPLE

**Q**

*(question)*

**A**

*(answer)*

**S**

*(student)*

**T**

*(teacher)*

**e.g.**

*(example)*

# Vowels 母音

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5 vowels (a, i, u, e, o), each clear and crisp -- shorter and more clipped than in English.

## EXAMPLE

**a**

*(father)*

**i**

*(king)*

**u**

*(put)*

**e**

*(pet)*

**o**

*(toe)*

# Voiceless Vowels

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Between or after voiceless consonants (k, s, sh, t, ts, ch, h, f, p), 'i' and 'u' are pronounced weakly.

## EXAMPLE

**tsuki**

*(moon)*

**desu**

*(to be)*

**hisho**

*(secretary)*

# Semi-vowel Y 半母音 Y

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A shorter, softer 'i' sound. Combines with a, u, or o as one syllable -- not two.

## EXAMPLE

**kyoo**

*(today)*

**kiyoo**

*(skillful)*

# Semi-vowel W 半母音 W

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Only followed by 'a'. 'Wa' is pronounced like 'ua' without rounding the lips.

## EXAMPLE

**watashi**

*(I / me)*



# Consonants 子音

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Followed by vowels, and lighter than in English. English 'l' and 'v' don't exist in Japanese. 'Z' doesn't vibrate at the tongue tip.

## EXAMPLE

sh

*(she)*

ts

*(wants)*

f

*(foot)*

# Japanese Pronunciation Guide

Japanese symbols and their English approximate pronunciation

## Consonant Sounds

**k** *as in*  
**kind**

**ch** *as in*  
**change**

**m** *as in*  
**my**

**j** *as in*  
**jumper**

**s** *as in*  
**sound**

**n** *as in*  
**knife**

**r** *as in*  
**ring**

**d** *as in*  
**dog**

**sh** *as in*  
**she**

**h** *as in*  
**hit**

**g** *as in*  
**give**

**p** *as in*  
**pink**

**t** *as in*  
**tongue**

**f** *as in*  
**foot**

**z** *as in*  
**zone**

**b** *as in*  
**big**

**ts** *as in*  
**wants**

# Fu Sound

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Made by protruding both lips, as if blowing out a candle.

## EXAMPLE

fuyu

*(winter)*

# R Sound

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A flapping sound, made by quickly touching the tongue tip to the gum behind the upper teeth.

## EXAMPLE

arigatoo

*(thank you)*

# G Sound (mid-word)

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Within a word, 'g' is close to the 'ng' sound, though this is optional.

## EXAMPLE

**eega**

*(movie)*

**shingoo**

*(traffic light)*

**kaigi**

*(conference)*

# Z Sound

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Does not vibrate at the top of the tongue the way the English 'z' does.

## EXAMPLE

mizu

*(water)*

# Double Consonant Sounds

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Doubled consonants (kk, ss, ssh, tt, tts, tch, pp) are pronounced with a brief held pause before release, like 'black cat' or 'hot tip' said quickly.

## EXAMPLE

**kitte**

*(stamp)*

**issho**

*(together)*

**hakkiri**

*(clearly)*

# Accent and Rhythm アクセント

Japanese uses pitch (high/low), not stress -- every syllable is the same length and speed, like a metronome that changes pitch. Same spelling with a different pitch pattern can mean something different.

## EXAMPLE

*dot height = pitch (higher = higher pitch)*



**a me**

*(candy)*



**a me**

*(rain)*



**se ki**

*(seat)*



**se ki**

*(cough)*



**ha ku shi**

*(doctorate)*



**ha ku shi**

*(white paper)*